Movie Studios Give Away Cash to Promote Films

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How do you get people excited about a new movie? Two movie **studios** tried a simple idea: give away money.

The film "How to Rob a Bank" opens in North American theaters on November 13. To **promote** it, a special **ATM** was placed in movie theaters around Los Angeles for four days. Fans who followed clues on social media could find the machine and a secret **PIN** and the machine would pay out a single $100 bill.

Another film, "Ebenezer," opens the same day. It is about Ebenezer Scrooge, the famous character who hates spending money. The **studio** set up a Venmo account for Scrooge. People asked the account for money but the only payments it sent were single cents!

One fan even sent the account about $30. A few days later, she got all her money back, plus an extra penny and an invitation to a special screening in New York.

Word Treasure

promote -- To advertise something and make people interested in it.

ATM -- A machine that gives out cash from your bank account when you use a card and a secret number.

PIN -- A secret number code you type to prove who you are, for example at a cash machine.

studio -- A company that makes films.

Background you need

Movie studios advertise new films so people will want to watch them.

Giving away money is a surprising trick to get attention.

One of the films is about a famous character who hates spending money, so paying people one cent is part of the joke.

Break it down

WHO: Two movie studios and their fans
WHAT: They promoted new films by giving away cash, from $100 bills to single cents
WHERE: In movie theaters around Los Angeles and on the Venmo app
WHY: Both stunts match their films -- one about robbing banks, the other about a man who hates spending money

Why it matters

Next time you see a company giving away money online, you will know it is an advertising trick -- and to be careful before sending money back.

Test what you remember

1. What did two movie studios do to promote their films?

- (A) Hide the films
- (B) Give away money
- (C) Give away houses
- (D) Cancel the films

2. What could the special ATM pay out?

- (A) A single $100 bill
- (B) Free popcorn
- (C) A movie ticket
- (D) A car

3. How could fans find the ATM?

- (A) A treasure map
- (B) By asking a bank
- (C) It never moved
- (D) Clues on social media

4. What did Scrooge's Venmo account send people?

- (A) Single cents
- (B) $100 bills
- (C) Movie posters
- (D) Birthday cards

5. When does 'How to Rob a Bank' open?

- (A) It already closed
- (B) Next year
- (C) November 13
- (D) December 25

6. What happened to the fan who sent the account about $30?

- (A) She lost it
- (B) She got it all back, plus an extra penny and a screening invitation
- (C) She got one cent only
- (D) Nothing happened

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: D 4: A 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):